in hot gas, the propagation of X-rays through the gas, and much much more. Few people could be masters of all this and, simultaneously, be masters of the intricate mathematics of curved spacetime. Human limitations forced a split in the community of researchers. Either you specialized in the theoretical physics of black holes, in deducing from general relativity the properties that black holes ought to have, or you specialized in the astrophysics of binary systems and hot gas falling onto black holes and radiation produced by the gas. You were either a *relativist* or an *astrophysicist*

Some of us tried to be both, with only modest success. Zel'dovich, the consummate astrophysicist, had occasional new insights about the fundamentals of black holes. I, as a somewhat talented relativist, tried to build general relativistic models of flowing gas near the black hole in Cyg X-1 But Zel'dovich didn't understand relativity deeply, and I didn't understand the astronomical lore very well. The barrier to cross over was enormous. Of all the researchers I knew in the golden age, only Novikov and Chandrasekhar had one foot firmly planted in astrophysics and the other in relativity.

Experimental physicists like Giacconi, who designed and flew X-ray detectors and satellites, faced a similar barrier. But there was a difference. Relativists were not needed in the search for black holes, whereas experimental physicists were essential. The observational astronomers and the astrophysicists, with their mastery of the tools for understanding binaries, gas flow, and X-ray propagation, could do nothing until the experimental physicists gave them detailed X-ray data. The experimental physicists often tried to decipher what their own data said about the gas flow and the possible black hole producing it, before turning the data over to the astronomers and astrophysicists, but with only modest success. The astronomers and astrophysicists thanked them very kindly, took the data, and then interpreted them in their own, more sophisticated and reliable ways.

This dependence of the astronomers and astrophysicists on the experimental physicists is but one of many interdependencies that were crucial to success in the search for black holes. Success, in fact, was a product of joint, mutually interdependent efforts by six different communities of people. Each community played an essential role. *Relativists* deduced, using the laws of general relativity, that black holes